

Name: _____

Date: _____

The Message in the Bottle

Grade 6 reading comprehension · Story · 13 points · About 30 minutes

The tide had pulled far out, leaving the beach littered with shells and tangled seaweed. Noor wandered along the waterline, kicking at pebbles, bored. Her family's vacation on the Oregon coast was supposed to be relaxing, but after three days of gray skies and cold wind, she had run out of things to do.

Then something glinted in the sand. She dropped to her knees and brushed away the wet grit. It was a glass bottle, green and cloudy, with a cork jammed in its neck. Inside, a tightly rolled piece of paper pressed against the glass.

It took Noor several minutes of twisting and tugging to pull out the cork. Her fingers shook as she unrolled the page, which was yellowed and soft as cloth. The ink had faded, but she could still read the words: "To whoever finds this: I'm ten years old, and I live in Japan. I wonder if you're a kid, too. Please write back." Below it was an address in Yokohama and a date. The date was fourteen years ago.

Noor sat back on her heels. Whoever wrote this was now twenty-four, almost grown up. Would the address even be the same? Would anyone still live there? She thought of all the miles of ocean the bottle must have crossed, tossed by storms and tugged by currents. The questions buzzed in her mind like bees. For the first time all week, she wasn't bored at all.

She ran up the beach, clutching the bottle to her chest, her sandals slapping against the wet sand. Her mother looked up from her book, startled. "Mom! Dad!" Noor shouted. "You will not believe what I just found!"

That night, Noor sat at the rickety table in the rental cabin and pulled out a sheet of paper. Outside, the wind rattled the window, but Noor barely noticed. She chewed on her pen for a long time. Then she began to write: "Dear stranger, I found your bottle. It took fourteen years, but it reached me."

1. Where was Noor's family on vacation? (1 point)

2. How did Noor feel at the start of the story? Cite two details from the first paragraph that show this. (2 points)

3. The story says something “glinted” in the sand. What does this word tell you about how the bottle looked? (1 point)

4. The story says, “The questions buzzed in her mind like bees.” What does this comparison suggest about Noor’s thoughts? (2 points)

5. Quote the sentence that shows Noor’s feelings had changed. Then explain how it shows the change. (2 points)

6. What can you infer about how old the bottle was? Cite evidence from the text. (2 points)

7. Why do you think Noor decided to write back? Support your answer with evidence from the text. (2 points)

8. Choose the statement that best expresses a theme of the story. Write its letter. (1 point)

- A. Family vacations by the ocean are always boring, so children should stay home instead.
- B. Beaches are dangerous places where children should never explore on their own.
- C. Glass bottles can float across the ocean for fourteen years without ever breaking.
- D. A small surprise can turn a dull day into an adventure and connect strangers.

Answer: _____

Writing task: Write the reply that comes back from Yokohama, or the next scene when Noor posts her letter.
